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APRIL 9
Tens of thousands march on the president's office. Demand? His resignation

APRIL 12
Sri Lanka announces default on external debt of $51 billion as after running out of foreign exchange to import desperately needed goods

APRIL 18
In a placatory move, Gotabaya unveils a new government, ousting two of his brothers and a nephew. Elder brother Mahinda remains PM.

APRIL 19
A protester dies in police firing, the first casualty of the agitation. The International Monetary Fund (IMF) asks Sri Lanka to restructure its external debt before a rescue package is arranged.

APRIL 28-MAY 6
On April 28, a general strike brings the country to a standstill. After another strike on May 6, Rajapaksa reimposes emergency. Trade unions and student activists join the strikes.



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May 9
On May 9, Mahinda Rajapaksa resigns as premier after violent clashes break out between his supporters and protesters. Three die.

MAY 11
Gotabaya offers to appoint new PM, cabinet, give up some power. But is silent on his resignation.

also declined rapidly, dropping to $1.9 billion by the end of March 2022, but as a bulk of these are not usable to settle USD denominated payments, the country's coffers are left with only $50 million as usable liquid reserves.

With no money to pay for imports, this has led to rising costs and the country has been gripped by shortage of fuel and domestic gas, which continue till today. Long queues of people waiting to buy gas or fill up their vehicles are commonplace. In addition, there are regular power cuts in a country heavily dependent on thermal power.

For the Rajapaksa-led government, the writing was on the wall for a year that the country was headed for a major economic crisis, but Gotabaya and Mahinda remained complacent, feeding dubious claims to the public that they had the situation under control. It was only when things reached a critical point in April this year that the president sacked his brother and finance minister Basil. He also dismissed the Governor of the Central Bank of Sri Lanka, Ajith Nivard Cabraal, a political appointee, who admitted the grave errors but had resisted taking a IMF bailout. By then the political fallout had begun and people had lost their faith in the Rajapaksas, including Gotabaya and Mahinda—the patriarch of the political family from Southern Sri Lanka.

In an environment where there is a trust deficit between the president and the public, Gotabaya has few options. He needs to urgently appoint a new prime minister and cabinet, but unless those he appoints can restore public confidence, such an exercise would be futile. He has been trying to get the Opposition to form a national government of all parties to run the country to address the economic crisis. But so far, they have not agreed, demanding his resignation. In an address to the nation on May 11, the president did promise to appoint a new prime minister and cabinet within the week and bring about constitutional changes that would reduce his powers. He also condemned the attacks on peaceful protestors and called for calm, but did not address demands for him to step down.

The main opposition is led by Sajith Premadasa, son of the late former president Ranasinghe Premadasa and leader of the Samagi Jana Balawegaya party. Premadasa is seen as the likely successor to Mahinda Rajapaksa as PM in an interim all-party government, but he is insisting that Gotabaya step down first.

Meanwhile, Gotabaya has imposed an emergency and deployed thousands of military personnel on the streets with shoot-at-sight orders to stop an escalation of violence. But any high-handed action will further alienate him and only hasten his departure. For now, Gotabaya Rajapaksa is confined to his highly fortified office in downtown Colombo. With the exit of his once powerful brother Mahinda and with Sri Lanka's economic collapse ever worsening in a politically unstable climate, his days in office are likely to be numbered. ■